

09

Modern Najdorf Sidelines

6.h3, 6.f3, and 6.Rg1: flexible attacking systems that hide their intentions.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will read the pawn and rook signals early enough to choose the correct center rather than reacting after the attack has formed.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 049 | PAGE 4

Decode: 6.h3 and the g4 plan*A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.*

LESSON 050 | PAGE 8

Play: 6.h3 and the g4 plan*A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.*

LESSON 051 | PAGE 12

Decode: 6.f3 without Be3*When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.*

LESSON 052 | PAGE 16

Play: 6.f3 without Be3*When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.*

LESSON 053 | PAGE 20

Decode: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm*A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.*

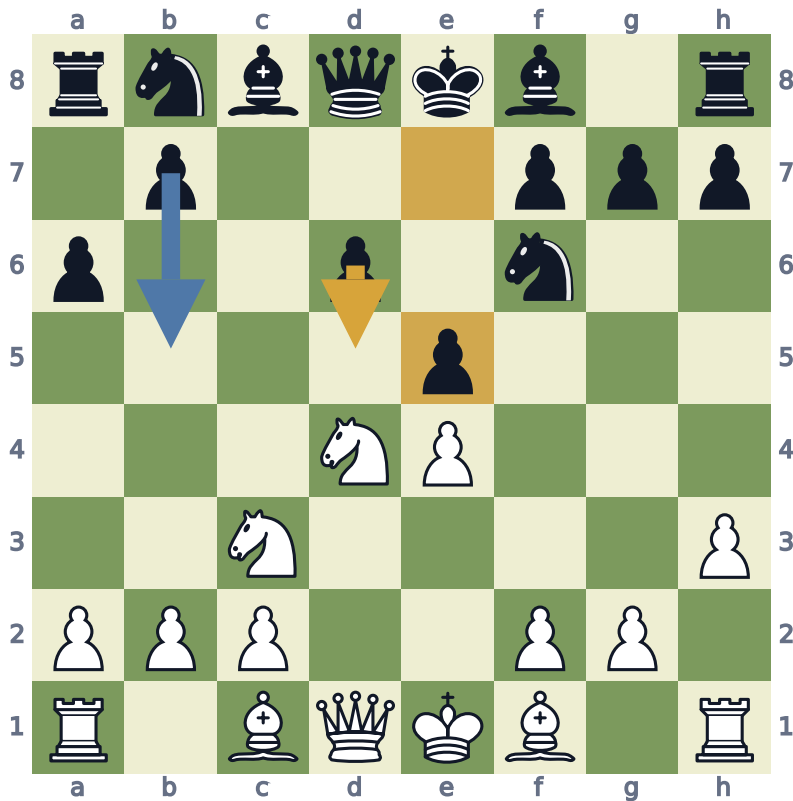
LESSON 054 | PAGE 24

Play: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm*A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will read the pawn and rook signals early enough to choose the correct center rather than reacting after the attack has formed.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: 6.h3 and the g4 plan

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

h3 prevents ...Ng4 and prepares g4 without declaring the bishop or queen, making Black's move-order choice important.

DECISION RULE

Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Choose a central structure that controls d5 and strike on the queenside before White's flexible setup becomes a full attack.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5.

MEMORY RULE | A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

h3 prevents ...Ng4 and prepares g4 without declaring the bishop or queen, making Black's move-order choice important.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Choose a central structure that controls d5 and strike on the queenside before White's flexible setup becomes a full attack.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5.

FAILURE MODE

Ignoring the setup because it lacks an immediate threat.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

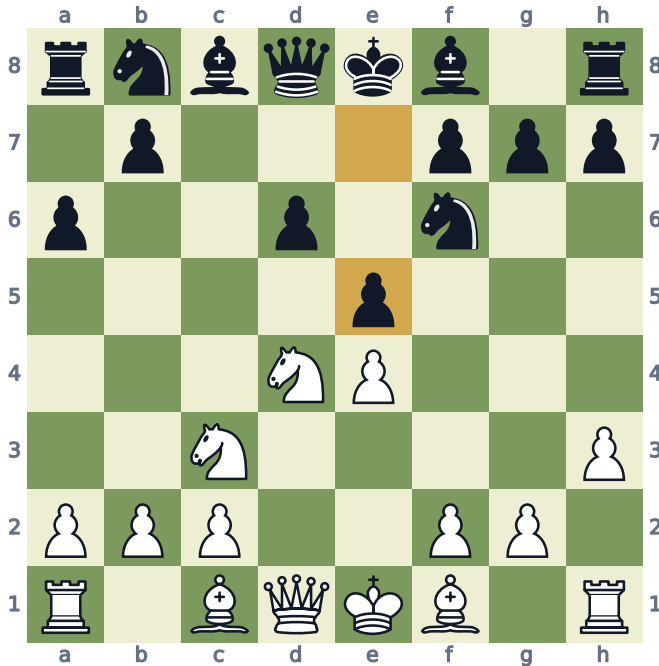
RULE | A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. h3 e5 7. Nde2 Be7 8. g4 Be6 9. Bg2



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- h3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

h3 prevents ...Ng4 and prepares g4 without declaring the bishop or queen, making Black's move-order choice important.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired? White's resistance is: White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5. The line fails as a template when: Ignoring the setup because it lacks an immediate threat.

STORE THIS | A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. h3 prevents ...Ng4 and prepares g4 without declaring the bishop or queen, making Black's move-order choice important. 2. Choose a central structure that controls d5 and strike on the queenside before White's flexible setup becomes a full attack. 3. White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5. 4. Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired? 5. Ignoring the setup because it lacks an immediate threat.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. h3 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: 6.h3 and the g4 plan



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

h3 prevents ...Ng4 and prepares g4 without declaring the bishop or queen, making Black's move-order choice important.

DECISION RULE

Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

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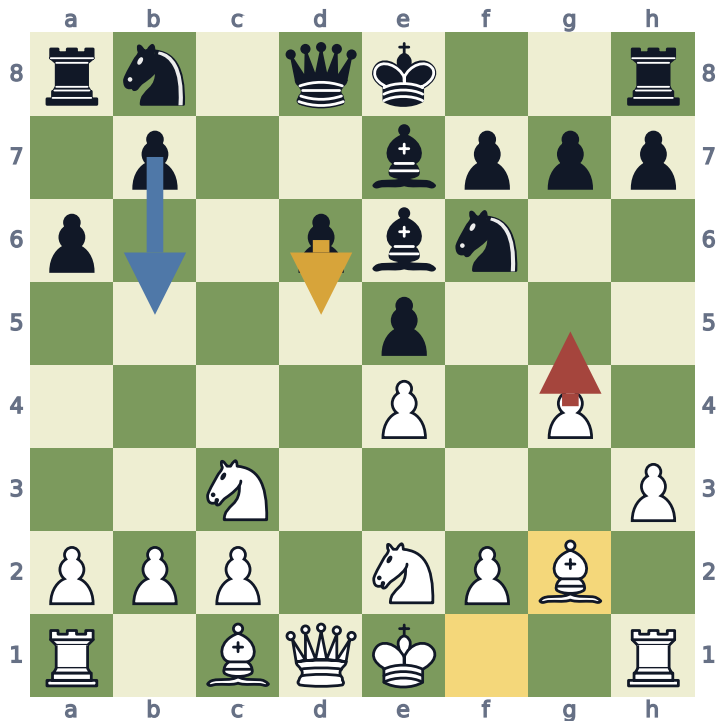
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White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5.

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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Choose a central structure that controls d5 and strike on the queenside before White's flexible setup becomes a full attack.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White plays g4, Bg2, and Ng3, combining kingside space with control of d5.

FAILURE MODE

Ignoring the setup because it lacks an immediate threat.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

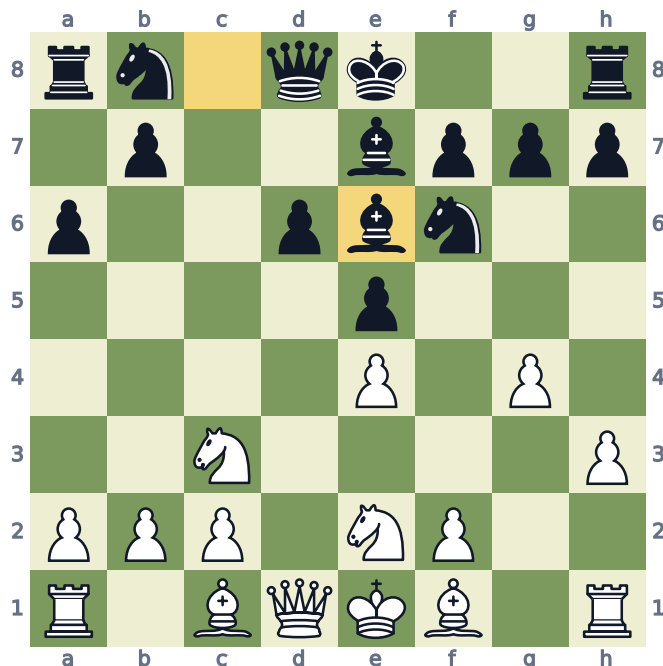
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. h3 e5 7. Nde2 Be7 8. g4 Be6 9. Bg2



- h3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Nde2: White reroutes a knight to e2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- g4: White starts a direct pawn storm and threatens to gain time on the f6 knight.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

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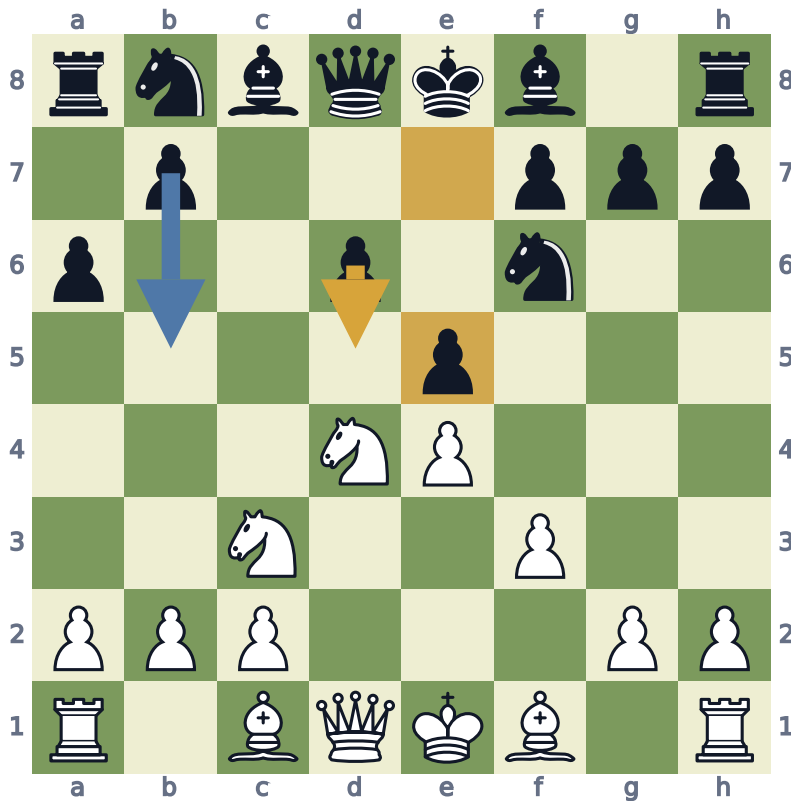
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. h3 e5 7. Nde2 Be7 8. g4 Be6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: 6.f3 without Be3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

f3 supports e4 and g4 while keeping the light bishop flexible; White may transpose or choose a quieter king placement.

DECISION RULE

Which transposition is White inviting, and can Black choose a version with one useful extra move?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5, complete development, and avoid revealing the king's destination too early.

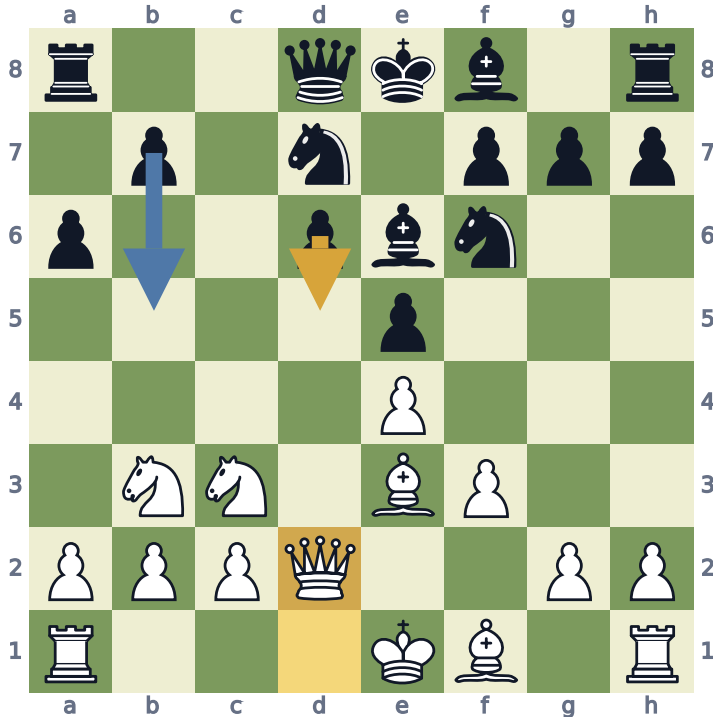
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White adapts: Be3-Qd2, g4, or a central plan depending on Black's setup.

MEMORY RULE | When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White adapts: Be3-Qd2, g4, or a central plan depending on Black's setup.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming f3 forces long castling and launching a premature queenside attack.

DECISION TEST

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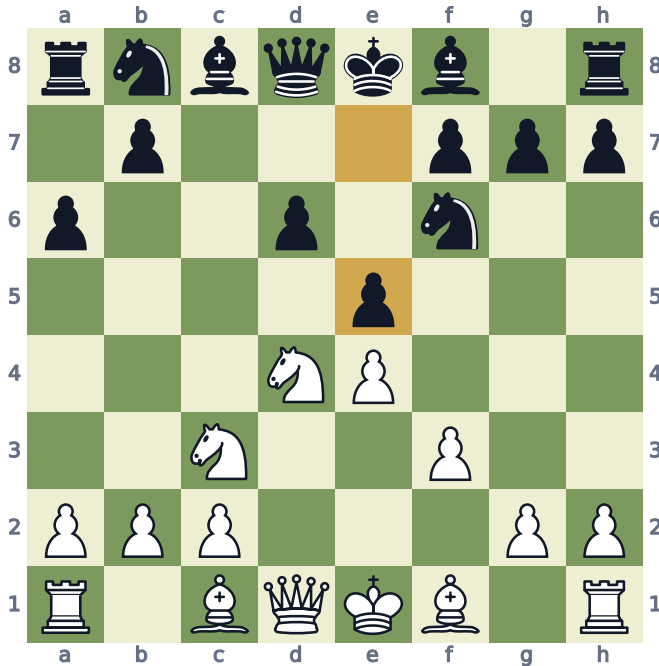
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
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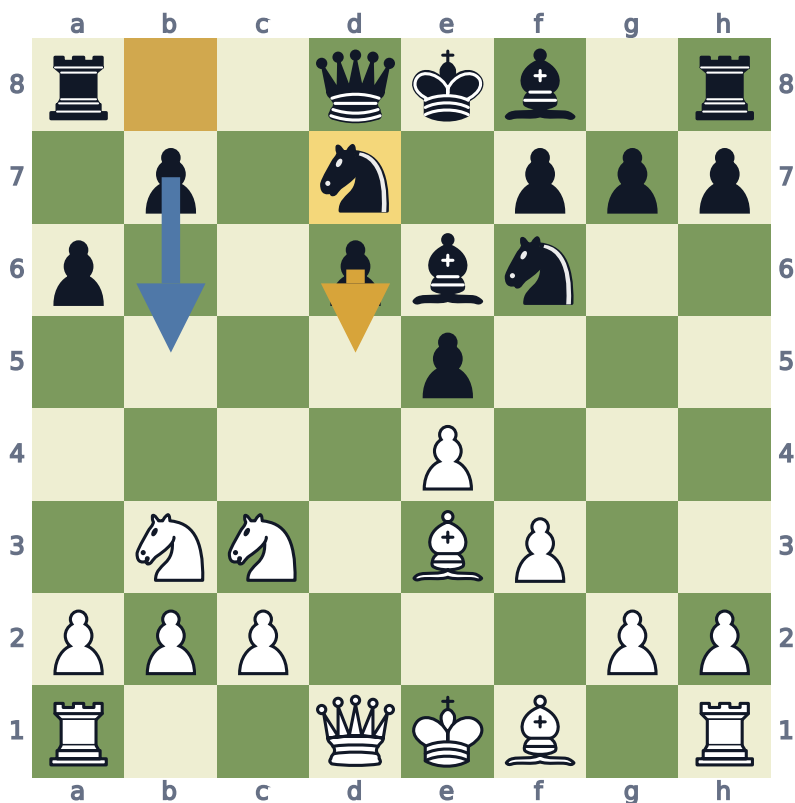
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Play: 6.f3 without Be3



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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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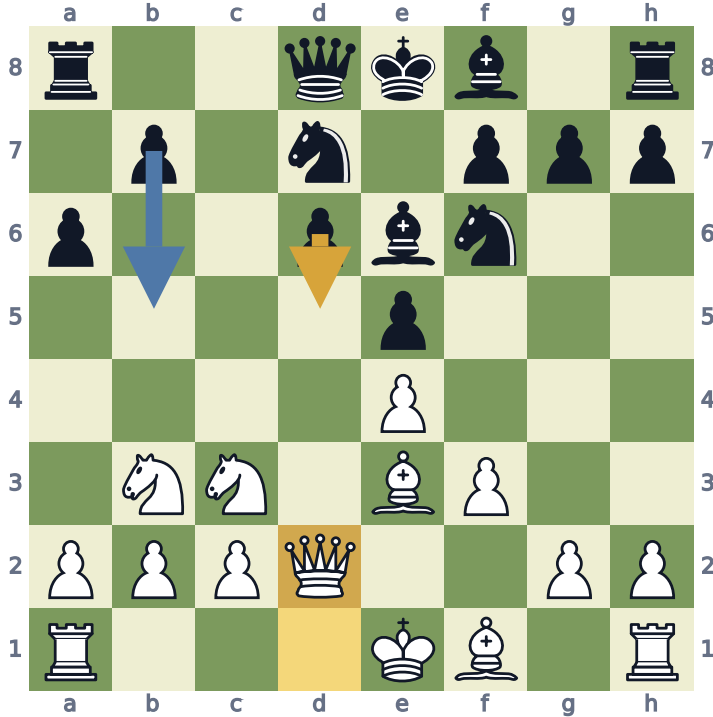
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

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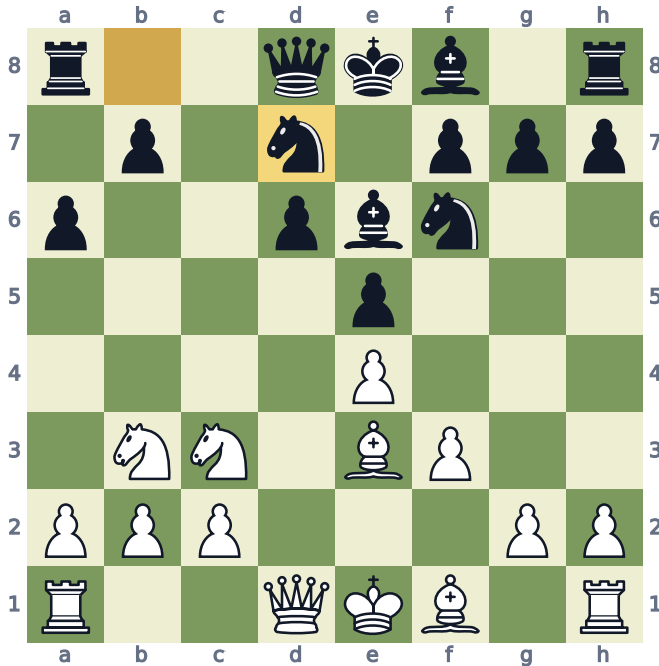
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Move-by-move meaning

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- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Nb3: White reroutes a knight to b3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

f3 supports e4 and g4 while keeping the light bishop flexible; White may transpose or choose a quieter king placement.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which transposition is White inviting, and can Black choose a version with one useful extra move? White's resistance is: White adapts: Be3-Qd2, g4, or a central plan depending on Black's setup. The line fails as a template when: Assuming f3 forces long castling and launching a premature queenside attack.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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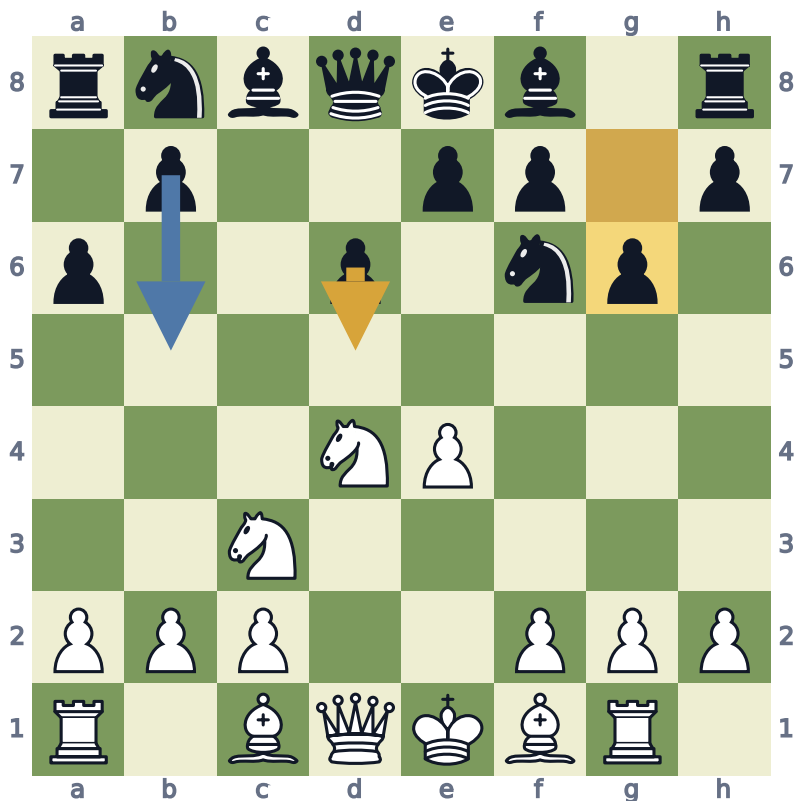
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. f3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. Be3 Nbd7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Rg1 commits to a direct g-pawn advance while keeping the king in the center or preparing queenside castling later.

DECISION RULE

Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Challenge the center and attack the overextended pawns; do not allow g5 to gain a free tempo on the f6 knight.

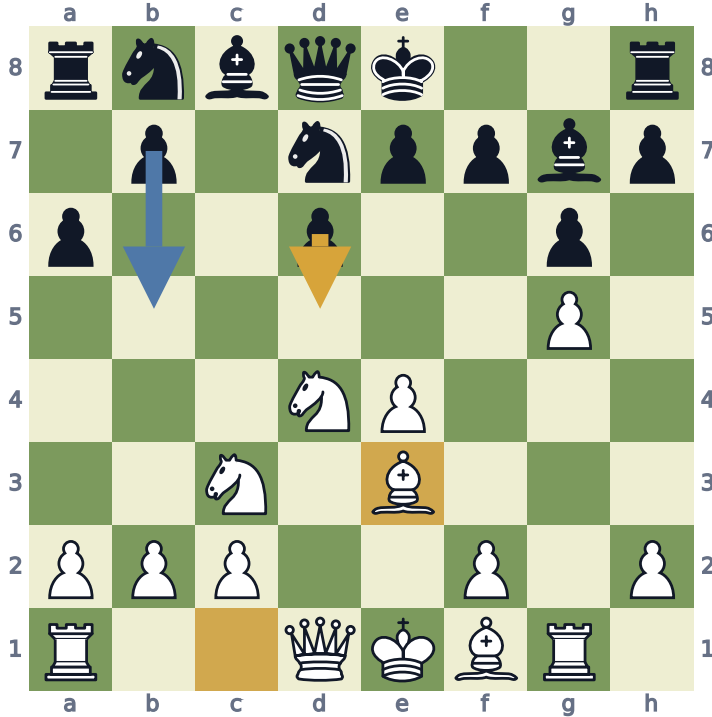
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White drives g4-g5, opens the g-file, and uses the rook immediately against the kingside.

MEMORY RULE | A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

Challenge the center and attack the overextended pawns; do not allow g5 to gain a free tempo on the f6 knight.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White drives g4-g5, opens the g-file, and uses the rook immediately against the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Castling into the advertised file without calculating the pawn contact.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

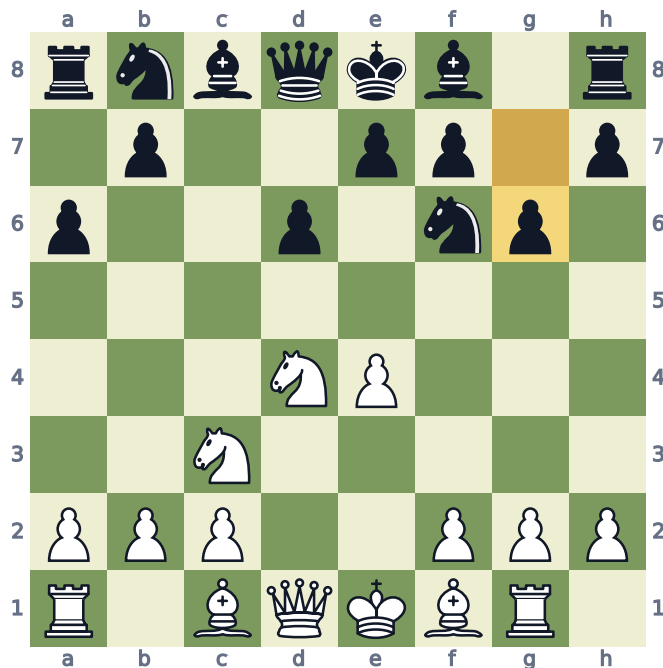
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Rg1 g6 7. g4 Bg7 8. g5 Nfd7 9. Be3



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Rg1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Rg1 commits to a direct g-pawn advance while keeping the king in the center or preparing queenside castling later.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense? White's resistance is: White drives g4-g5, opens the g-file, and uses the rook immediately against the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Castling into the advertised file without calculating the pawn contact.

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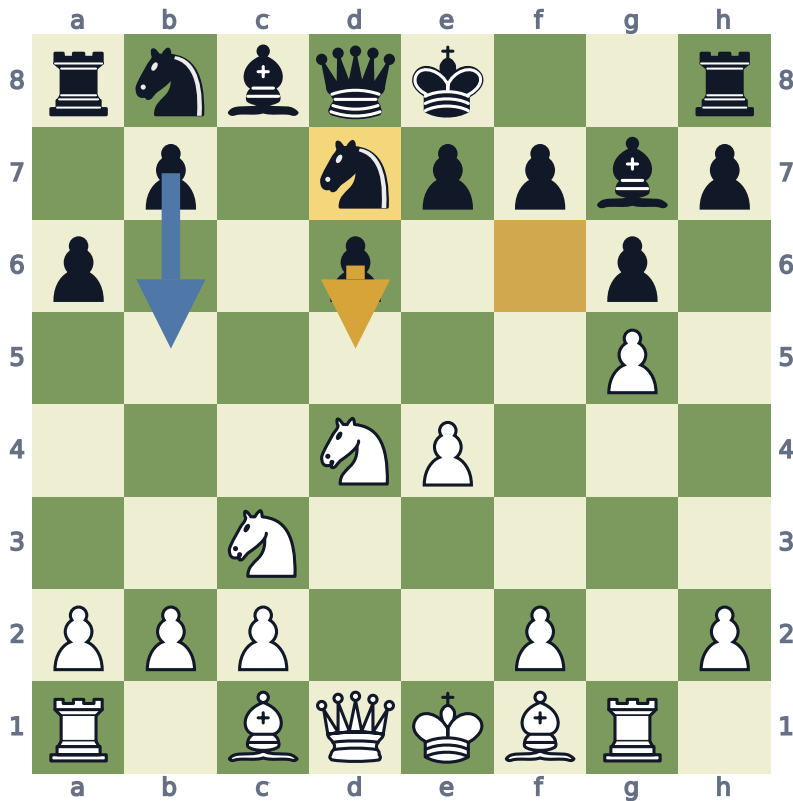
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Rg1 g6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm



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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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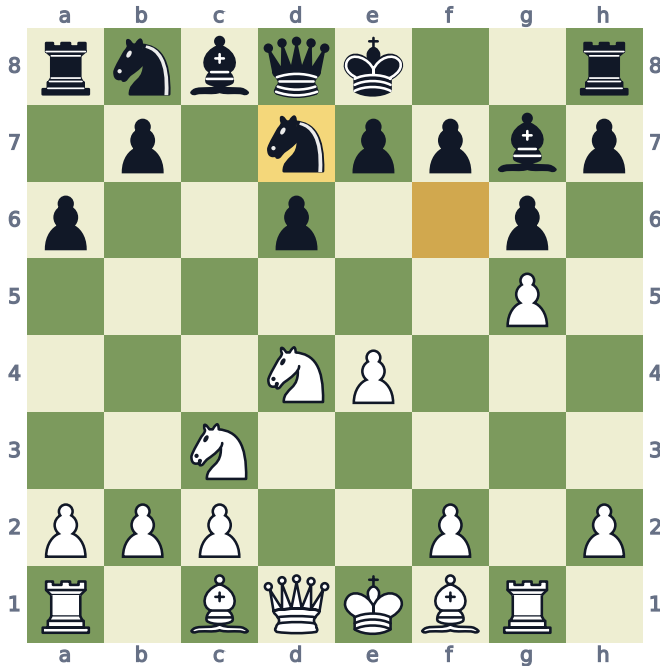
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- g4: White starts a direct pawn storm and threatens to gain time on the f6 knight.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- g5: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nfd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Rg1 commits to a direct g-pawn advance while keeping the king in the center or preparing queenside castling later.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense? White's resistance is: White drives g4-g5, opens the g-file, and uses the rook immediately against the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Castling into the advertised file without calculating the pawn contact.

STORE THIS | A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Rg1 commits to a direct g-pawn advance while keeping the king in the center or preparing queenside castling later. 2. Challenge the center and attack the overextended pawns; do not allow g5 to gain a free tempo on the f6 knight. 3. White drives g4-g5, opens the g-file, and uses the rook immediately against the kingside. 4. Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense? 5. Castling into the advertised file without calculating the pawn contact.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Rg1 g6 7. g4 Bg7 8. g5 Nfd7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 049 Decode: 6.h3 and the g4 plan

Prompt: Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired?

Recall: A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

LESSON 050 Play: 6.h3 and the g4 plan

Prompt: Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired?

Recall: A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

LESSON 051 Decode: 6.f3 without Be3

Prompt: Which transposition is White inviting, and can Black choose a version with one useful extra move?

Recall: When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.

LESSON 052 Play: 6.f3 without Be3

Prompt: Which transposition is White inviting, and can Black choose a version with one useful extra move?

Recall: When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.

LESSON 053 Decode: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm

Prompt: Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense?

Recall: A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.

LESSON 054 Play: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm

Prompt: Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense?

Recall: A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

6.h3 and the g4 plan

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. h3 e5 7. Nde2 Be7 8. g4 Be6 9. Bg2

Decision: Has h3 signaled g4, and does ...e5 help or give White the exact d5 route desired?

Memory: A waiting move can carry a plan; read what it prevents and prepares.

CARD 2

6.f3 without Be3

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. f3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. Be3 Nbd7 9. Qd2

Decision: Which transposition is White inviting, and can Black choose a version with one useful extra move?

Memory: When the opponent stays flexible, improve pieces without making irreversible weaknesses.

CARD 3

6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Rg1 g6 7. g4 Bg7 8. g5 Nfd7 9. Be3

Decision: Where will the f6 knight go after g5, and does that route improve or disorganize Black's defense?

Memory: A rook move in the opening is a warning: identify the file it intends to open.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
049 Decode: 6.h3 and the g4 plan	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
050 Play: 6.h3 and the g4 plan	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
051 Decode: 6.f3 without Be3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
052 Play: 6.f3 without Be3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
053 Decode: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
054 Play: 6.Rg1 and the rook-led storm	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.